

The boy jumped at the offer as he had been orphaned earlier and was living with his sister whose husband would often beat him up and leave him hungry. Ironically, Chhotu was so taken in by his traffickers that he convinced two more boys of his age to go along with him. Two traffickers, Rajdeep Yadav and Heeralal Yadav, have been arrested in this connection.

This batch of hapless boys too was headed for Punjab when they were rescued. As Bhola Singh, officer-in-charge of Baijnathpur police outpost, reveals, the traffickers had paid the families of the boys, excluding Chhotu, Rs 1,500 each for one year on the promise of getting their children employment as labourers in Punjab.

"With no employment available after the floods, we were forced to send our children to earn," says a mother-of-fact Sumitra Devi, mother of 11-year-old Santosh, one of the freed children. "We have faced desperate times. The entire locality was under water and we could return to our village only a month after," recalls Jagdish Ravidas of Pararia, adding that many from the area are still missing, though he had saved some lives as he could swim.

Besides the directly affected areas, the Child Line at Kishanganj rescued 23 children on five separate occasions after the Kosi breached an embankment in August last year. Many villagers of adjoining districts used to get seasonal employment in Madhepura, Supaul, Purnia and Saharsa districts. They were jobless after the floods though their villages were not under water. Several such families just let go of their children.

Many FIRs have been lodged against child traffickers in Katihar, Saharsa, Kishanganj, Raxual and with the Railway Police, and arrests of nearly a dozen buyers have been made during the past six months. INDIA TODAY has copies of five such FIRs lodged against traffickers in Saharsa and Katihar districts. But ironically, such FIRs serve little purpose.

While most traffickers escape and

some are arrested, children who are rescued from them are not referred to the courts or other legal authorities. They are detained for a few hours before being sent back to their parents who, to begin with, are also accountable as they allowed their children to go for financial reasons. There is no official record of all the rescued children with either the Government or the police authorities. The arrest of the brokers also guarantees little as nobody knows how many are still at large and on the lookout for children. Many of them have succeeded in obtaining bail in the past as the police and the prosecution lose interest over time.

Aditya Rajhansh, assistant labour commissioner in Saharsa, says the police are empowered to take cognisance of trafficking. "We have also lodged FIRs against child traffickers and rescued children in Saharsa," he adds, conceding, however, that because of several transit points, it is not always possible to catch hold of all traffickers and rescue all victims. Another Labour Department official in Patna argues that the police are still not doing much to address the



▲ **LALTU YADAV** 8 years

Gamharia Village, Saharsa

Sold for Rs 1,200 to a Punjab farmer who used him as a bonded labourer. He was burned on his buttocks with a heated iron rod when he wanted to return home. Two scars are still prominent. Ran away with the help of another Bihar labourer. Reached Saharsa on January 14.

Police Case Status The police have arrested one middleman. The second one is still at large. No action taken against the child's employer.

From the Clutches

October 2008

68 children are rescued from traffickers in Saharsa.

January 8, 2009

Saharsa cops rescue 12 children (the oldest was 12) and arrest two. The traffickers had paid their families Rs 1,500 per child for one year.

January 17, 2009

Katihar police rescue 15 children between seven and 14, while being trafficked to Delhi. Five arrested.

January 24, 2009

36 children freed at Katihar railway station from traffickers.

Feb 27-March 14, 2009

54 children rescued at Supaul railway station while being trafficked to Punjab and other areas. Two nabbed and sent to jail. One escapes from custody.

